

The Best Places to Eat Nasi Goreng

Jalan Malioboro Night Market inexpensive

The best nasi goreng in Yogya is found in this wonderfully atmospheric market, where small restaurant stands give you the chance to try *lesehan* dining – sitting on bamboo mats at a low table, rubbing elbows with the locals while mouthwatering food is prepared in front of you. Aside from nasi goreng, try Yogya and Javanese specialties such as *nasi gudeg* (steamed rice with curry made from hefty, heavily scented jackfruit); tempeh (slightly sour, fermented soybean cake, usually sliced and fried); *nasi langgi* (steamed rice served on a banana leaf with a dozen spoonfuls of various curries and *sambals*); Kalasan chicken, stewed, fried, and flavored with copious garlic; and *bakpia pathok* (fried mung bean pastries, similar to Chinese mooncakes). For dessert, *cendol* is a drink of luridly colored jelly noodles in iced, sweetened coconut milk that – despite being served throughout Southeast Asia – locals insist originated in Java. Otherwise, *wedang ronde*, glutinous rice balls served in ginger syrup, is definitely a Yogya dish.

Jalan Malioboro, Kraton, Yogyakarta;
open from dusk daily

Also in Yogyakarta

Also in the Kraton, **Bale Raos (+62 274 415 550; moderate)** serves excellent nasi goreng, though it specializes in recipes from the Yogyakarta Sultanate, some of them attributed to former rulers themselves. *Urip urip gulung* is fried catfish stewed in coconut milk flavored with ginger, *makrut* lime leaves, and lemongrass; while *sanggar* is, conversely, previously stewed beef cubes grilled on bamboo sticks like a satay.

Also in Java

In Jakarta, Java's hot, sprawling, chaotic, unwieldy capital, **Seribu Rasa (www.seriburasa.com; moderate)** sets the standard for mid-range restaurants serving regional Indonesian cooking, with stylish wooden decor. The menu includes several takes on nasi goreng: try *nasi sayur* (fried rice with vegetables) or fried-rice *sundah kelapa*, a seafood variation named after Jakarta's harbor area and fish market (where, incidentally, you can still see fleets of old-style wooden fishing boats pulled up at the wharf).

Around the World

BaliBali (www.balibalirestaurant.com; moderate) in London's West End is a relaxed, friendly place in which to try a host of Indonesian staples, including perfect nasi goreng, gado-gado (a salad with boiled eggs, tempeh, bean sprouts, and mild peanut sauce), plain Indonesian fried chicken, and spicy squid *sambal*.



Above Turning rice at the market: the soil in this region, enriched by volcanic ash, is said to produce wonderfully aromatic grains

Left Nasi goreng knows no social barriers: Indonesians relish their national dish at street stands, in restaurants, and even at banquets